WEEKLY JOURNAL DIGEST

Weekly journal digest for 2026-09-28 to 2026-10-03

Curated articles in political communication and computational social science.

SPECIAL ISSUE UPDATES

Calls checked: 2026-10-03.

Manual calls omitted pending renewed official-page verification: Public Relations Review.

Special Issue: New Directions in Influencer Research
Journal of Advertising Research | Deadline within 14 days | call for papers
Deadline: 2026-10-12
Official call / submission details

Special Issue: Older Adult Communication Across Contexts
Communication Quarterly | Deadline within 14 days | call for papers
Deadline: 2026-10-15
Official call / submission details

Thematic Issue: Reconceptualizing Deliberative Democracy and Journalism in AI-Mediated Public Spheres
Media and Communication | Updated | call for papers
Deadline: 2026-10-15
Official call / submission details

Thematic Issue: Social Media Journalism as a One-Way Street?
Media and Communication | Updated | call for papers
Deadline: 2026-10-15
Official call / submission details

Special Collection: From Minds to Society: Linking Individual, Social, and Political Dynamics for Collective Climate Action
npj Climate Action | Newly found | call for papers
Deadline: 2027-02-15
Official call / submission details

Thematic Issue: The Platformization of Local News
Media and Communication | Newly found | call for papers
Deadline: 2027-05-15
Official call / submission details

SUMMARY

This week, COMAP Journal Bot examines how messages, group identities, and institutions shape collective choices. New studies connect online hate speech and counter-speech to minority collective action, trace the electoral consequences of minority representation in India, and examine how shared responsibility between citizens and politicians complicates democratic accountability. A computational analysis of Brazilian presidential candidates' tweets distinguishes strategically timed from consistent populist communication across electoral and policy contexts.

The methods reading is especially useful this week: political conjoint experiments reveal individual differences in decision strategies, a citizenship meta-analysis exposes the importance of identification design, and a new experimental-computational study shows how effort and opportunity shape contested judgments of merit. An extreme-heat reanalysis tests how dependence and model selection alter uncertainty; previously undelivered catch-up papers extend the discussion to scarcity, digital governance, inequality, and collective information dynamics.

You may have received two September 7 emails because the first was sent before that collection window closed; the second completed the same edition. Saturday delivery now aligns collection and sending, so each future email represents a distinct Monday-Saturday edition.

HIGHLIGHTS

Classifying strategy use in multiattribute subjective choice: Application to conjoint experiments in political science

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-09-28

Why it matters · Models the decision strategies individuals use in political conjoint experiments, showing why aggregate attribute effects can conceal different heuristics and preferences.

Open article →

From Hate Speech to Collective Action Intentions: The Role of Counter-Speech and Accuracy Cues Among Targeted Minorities

COMMUNICATION RESEARCH · 2026-09-29

Why it matters · Tests how counter-speech and accuracy cues shape minority groups' responses to online hate speech, connecting platform interventions with injustice, efficacy, and collective action.

Open article →

The Representation Trap: How Minority Power Shapes Electoral Politics in India

AMERICAN POLITICAL SCIENCE REVIEW · 2026-10-02

Why it matters · Shows how minority representation can simultaneously fragment minority votes and consolidate majority support, using elections, surveys, interviews, and a vignette experiment in India.

Open article →

When Populism? Consistent and Opportunistic Populist Communication in the 2022 Brazilian Presidential Elections

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-10-01

Why it matters · Uses fine-tuned BERT classifiers to distinguish consistent from strategically timed populist appeals in Brazilian campaign tweets, connecting computational measurement with electoral and policy context.

Open article →

Democratic Accountability with Citizen Coproduction

AMERICAN POLITICAL SCIENCE REVIEW · 2026-09-29

Why it matters · Explains why shared responsibility between citizens and politicians can complicate blame and electoral accountability even when policy reform has good prospects.

Open article →

The economic returns to citizenship: Evidence from a meta-analysis

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-09-28

Why it matters · Finds that the estimated earnings return to citizenship depends strongly on research design, with a randomized study near zero despite a positive pooled average.

Open article →

Psychological and computational evidence that merit is a constructed evaluative process

SCIENCE ADVANCES · 2026-10-02

Why it matters · Separates effort from opportunity-dependent output in preregistered studies, showing how opposing conceptions of deservingness can underlie resource-allocation judgments.

Open article →

Inoculating against fatalistic beliefs: a comparative test of narrative and non-narrative strategies

JOURNAL OF COMMUNICATION · 2026-10-01

Why it matters · Compares narrative and non-narrative inoculation messages in a randomized experiment, clarifying how message format and baseline beliefs affect resistance to conflicting information.

Open article →

TABLE OF CONTENTS

New This Week

- American Political Science Review
- Communication Research
- Journal of Communication
- Nature
- Nature Communications
- Nature Human Behaviour
- Political Communication
- Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences
- Science Advances

Previous Week Catch-Up

- Communication Research
- Nature Communications
- Nature Human Behaviour
- Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences
- Science
- Science Advances

COLLECTION SNAPSHOT

TOTAL COLLECTED CANDIDATES	NEW THIS WEEK CANDIDATES	PREVIOUS WEEK CATCH-UP CANDIDATES
308	135	173
LATE ADDITIONS CANDIDATES		
0		

Curated digest below: 19 new, 10 catch-up, 0 late additions

Counts follow automated source filters and precede manual relevance review. Saturday collection was refreshed through 2026-10-03.

All 17 sources completed. Catch-up contains only previously undelivered papers; September 26 selections are not repeated.

Six abstracts are unavailable. Optional Semantic Scholar enrichment was disabled; no source failures or enrichment errors were recorded.

Secondary selections include utility policy and human social proximity. The echo-chamber model concerns biological collectives, not direct human evidence.

FULL CURATED DIGEST

New This Week

American Political Science Review

The Representation Trap: How Minority Power Shapes Electoral Politics in India

2026-10-02 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101774

FEYAAD ALLIE

Harvard University

Abstract. Liberal democracy requires that minority groups be represented in politics. This article argues that minority representation can also generate headwinds for political inclusion by dividing the minority group and consolidating the dominant group. I study the combination of these processes, termed the representation trap, through a mixed-methods examination of Muslims in India. Analyses of election results and an original survey of Hindu and Muslim voters show that electing a Muslim representative divides Muslim votes across an increased share of coethnic candidates and consolidates Hindu votes for the majoritarian party in the subsequent election. Qualitative evidence and a vignette experiment trace these patterns to two mechanisms: sub-identity activation among Muslims and super-ordinate identity mobilization among Hindus. By showing how representation restructures elite and voter behavior within both minority and dominant groups, the article highlights the dynamic nature of ethnic politics and complicates the view of minorities as politically unified.

Read article →

Democratic Accountability with Citizen Coproduction

2026-09-29 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101889

JIE MA; KEITH E. SCHNAKENBERG; IAN R. TURNER

University of Pittsburgh; Washington University in St Louis

Abstract. Many policies require citizens to actively participate in their implementation in order to be successful, a situation referred to as citizen coproduction. Though citizen coproduction is necessary in many policy areas, it could create difficulties for democratic accountability because citizens and politicians share responsibility for policy failures and attribution of blame may be difficult. We analyze the problem of democratic accountability with citizen coproduction in the context of a model in which politicians, who vary with respect to their competence at selecting policies, choose whether to implement policies whose success depends on citizen coproduction choices. For citizens, the problem is one of attribution: when coproduction is low, it may be hard to select good incumbents because policy failures are frequent even when policy choices are good. Incumbents anticipate these effects, which sometimes implies that they are less likely to choose reforms when they are more likely to be successful.

Read article →

Marriage as Slavery: Oroonoko, the Slave Trade, and the Origins of English Feminism

2026-09-29 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101890

MARY JO MACDONALD

Mount Allison University

Abstract. Abstract This article investigates Mary Astell's controversial comparison of marriage to slavery. While existing scholarship situates this analogy within the neo-Roman republican framework, which defined slavery as subjection to absolute rule, I investigate another paradigm: the transatlantic slave trade. To make this case, the article traces the influence of Aphra Behn's Oroonoko (1688) on early feminist thought. By foregrounding the market logic underpinning chattel slavery, Behn popularized the idea that slavery's harms were rooted, not in absolute power, but in the commodification of human beings. Astell appropriated this insight, showing that marriage resembled slavery not because husbands wielded power over wives but because the institution had been commodified: women were treated as things to be bought and sold. In uncovering this genealogy of feminist thought, the article highlights the enduring contributions of the "first" English feminists-insights that are entangled with, and shaped by, the development of the slave trade.

Read article →

What Would It Mean to Democratize Finance? An Evaluation of Divergent Conceptions of Democracy and Finance

2026-09-29 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101968

LEAH DOWNEY; STEFAN EICH

Georgetown University; King's College London

Abstract. Calls to "democratize finance" abound today. Yet this apparent consensus obscures sharply divergent conceptions of both democracy and finance. This article maps these demands along two axes, distinguishing between access- and power-based conceptions of democracy, and between three dimensions of finance: payment, capital markets, and banking. We then develop three normative claims. First, we argue that conceptions that reduce democratization to expanded market access are not merely insufficient but, when applied to speculative capital markets, amount to predatory inclusion. Second, thicker accounts of democratization as equal inclusion are normatively more promising but internally unstable, as their democratic commitments generate pressures toward power sharing. Third, the most plausible conceptions of democratizing finance are power-centered and involve greater public control over credit creation and allocation. Rather than defending a single institutional solution, the article assesses a range of reform proposals while specifying a normative threshold for evaluating what it would mean to democratize finance.

Read article →

Communication Research

From Hate Speech to Collective Action Intentions: The Role of Counter-Speech and Accuracy Cues Among Targeted Minorities

2026-09-29 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261489660

Desiree Schmuck; Magdalena Obermaier; Nancy Molina-Rogers; Muniba Saleem

LMU Munich, Germany; University of California, Los Angeles, USA; University of California, Santa Barbara, USA; University of Vienna, Austria

Abstract. Online hate speech targeting minority groups poses a significant social identity threat to those affected, often prompting coping strategies like out-group avoidance or derogation, which can harm intergroup relations in diverse societies. However, collective action as an empowering response has received limited attention in this context. Drawing on the social identity model of collective action (SIMCA), this study examines both the mechanisms and boundary conditions of online hate speech's impact on minority groups. Across two experiments (N Study1 = 328 Muslims; N Study2 = 583 Latinos), we find that online hate speech increases group-based injustice, which in turn drives collective action intentions, supporting the SIMCA. This effect is amplified when information embedded in the online hate speech is perceived as inaccurate or flagged for inaccuracy. In Study 2, we further demonstrate that counter-speech can reduce group-based injustice and, when paired with low-accuracy hate speech, enhance collective efficacy beliefs.

Read article →

Media Use for Strong and Weak Ties: A Configural Examination of Personal Media System and Well-Being

2026-09-28 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261487784

Ceciley X. Zhang; Ronald E. Rice

California State University, Fullerton, USA; University of Santa Barbara, CA, USA

Abstract. Taking a configural approach to personal media use, this study examined how strong- and weak-tie media configuration relate to digital stress and well-being. Using a sample of 1,197 U.S. adults (analytic N = 1,143), we explored how media configuration attributes (size, density, and centralization by tie strength, and homogeneity) are associated with well-being, directly and indirectly through five dimensions of digital stress (overconnectivity, communication overload, deficient self-regulation, self-presentation pressure, and technological frustration). Our results highlight the importance of maintaining a larger, more interconnected, and centralized weak-tie configuration, and overall, a more uniform configuration, for well-being benefits (direct and indirect). Notably, larger weak-tie configuration is indirectly associated with lower well-being through greater technological frustration, while larger strong-tie configuration is indirectly associated with higher well-being through lower technological frustration. These findings emphasize the relational context of communication media use and suggest tie-specific strategies for managing communication flows and supporting well-being.

Read article →

Journal of Communication

Inoculating against fatalistic beliefs: a comparative test of narrative and non-narrative strategies

2026-10-01 · DOI 10.1093/JOC/JQAG018

Minyi Chen; Hye Kyung Kim

Wee Kim Wee School of Communication and Information, Nanyang Technological University ,

Abstract. Abstract This study compares the effectiveness of narrative and non-narrative inoculation messages in reducing fatalistic beliefs and fostering resistance to conflicting cancer information. A two-phase randomized experiment (N = 572 in Phase 1; n = 332 in Phase 2) tested their effects on counterarguing against attack, cancer fatalism, perceived efficacy, and intentions to adopt cancer risk-reduction behaviors. Compared with control, both inoculation messages reduced cancer fatalism, enhanced perceived efficacy, and increased certain intentions to adopt certain risk-reduction behaviors. Narrative inoculation elicited more counterarguing against attack than the non-narrative counterpart. Inoculation effects also varied by baseline fatalism, functioning therapeutically by immediately reducing initially high fatalism and, more modestly, prophylactically by maintaining initially low fatalism. These findings extend inoculation theory by elucidating the role of message format in sustaining resistance to negative media effects, and by demonstrating the theory's potential dual prophylactic-therapeutic functionality in a fatalistic belief context.

Read article →

Nature

AI can widen science - but only if institutions stop rewarding the already measurable

2026-09-29 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-02961-Z

Guowei Huang; Xiang Hu; Pengsong Zhang; Zhicheng Lin

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

Nature Communications

Nationwide sustainability assessment of PFAS treatment in U.S. water utilities

2026-10-01 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-77509-W

Md. Moshiur Rahman Tushar; Zaki Alam Pushan; Christopher Sutton Page; Nirupam Aich; Lewis Stetson Rowles

Abstract. Abstract Per- and polyfluoroalkyl substances (PFAS) pose an unprecedented challenge for US drinking water systems as new national regulations mandate their removal. While granular activated carbon (GAC) and ion exchange (IX) resins are widely applied, their economic and environmental sustainability under diverse real-world conditions remains uncertain. Here we leverage a quantitative sustainable design framework (integrated techno-economic analysis and life cycle assessment) to evaluate GAC and IX performance across utilities nationwide. Through uncertainty and sensitivity analyses, we identify utility size, water types (e.g., groundwater and surface water), and PFAS chain length as the dominant drivers of cost and environmental impacts. IX consistently shows lower global warming potential than GAC, though treatment of short-chain PFAS significantly increases costs. Water quality, especially total organic carbon, affects treatment performance and can change cost and environmental impacts for GAC. Results highlight disproportionate burdens on small and rural systems and the trade-offs inherent in technology selection. This work provides actionable insight for utilities and policymakers, enabling more equitable and sustainable strategies for meeting emerging PFAS standards.

Read article →

Religious celibacy is linked to marriage and wealth transmission practices across different world religions

2026-09-29 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-78153-0

Gabriel Saffa; Sara Sherbaji; Ruth Mace

Abstract. Abstract Lifelong religious celibacy may seem to be an evolutionary puzzle. However, it is possible that where siblings compete for parental resources, families can benefit from having some offspring become celibate monks or nuns. Here, we test whether celibacy is more likely to be found in societies with substantial marriage transactions, lower levels of polygyny, and heritable wealth, especially land. Additionally, we predict male celibacy to be linked to polygyny and bride-wealth, and female celibacy to monogamy or polyandry and to dowry. Using Bayesian phylogenetic multilevel models on a cross-cultural sample of 352 societies, we find that celibacy occurs mainly in monogamous societies with heritable wealth, and male and female celibacy are more common where marriage payments are higher for the celibate sex. Buddhism and Christianity are especially likely to institutionalize celibacy, suggesting that the emergence of celibate religious institutions reflects common responses to similar socio-ecological conditions across cultures.

Read article →

Environmental stochasticity reduces human planning effort

2026-09-28 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-78023-9

Jordan Lei; Jeroen Olieslagers; Nastaran Arfaei; Daisy Xinlei Lin; Wei Ji Ma

Abstract. Abstract The world is stochastic, making planning difficult. Despite the ubiquity of stochasticity in real-world environments, it remains an open question how people effectively balance the cognitive costs of planning against its potential benefits when faced with stochasticity. To study this, we designed a planning task where participants face one of three forms of stochasticity commonly encountered in the real world: reliability, volatility, and controllability. We find a robust pattern across all three manipulations: as stochasticity increases, people reduce their planning effort as measured by first-choice response times. To understand the processes underlying this effect, we developed several computational cognitive models to account for participants' choices. We find that rather than calculating expected values optimally, people choose a simpler strategy, acting as if the world were deterministic, a phenomenon known as determinizing. Consistent with our response time findings, we find that people reduce their effort by decreasing their sensitivity to values with increasing stochasticity, a signature of policy compression. Our work highlights the often overlooked role of stochasticity in human planning and its impact on planning strategy and effort. Moreover, it reveals the limitations of studying stochasticity solely through single-shot decisions.

Read article →

Nature Human Behaviour

Gendered motives for group formidability among children and adults

2026-10-02 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02606-1

Erik K. Fonn; Joakim H. Zahl; Bjrn D. Kristensen; Lotte Thomsen

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

Political Communication

When Populism? Consistent and Opportunistic Populist Communication in the 2022 Brazilian Presidential Elections

2026-10-01 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2735922

Gustavo Venturelli; Paolo Ricci; Guilherme Tiengo; Raphaela Martins Guedes Azevedo Velho

Independent Researcher; Stetson University; University of Sao Paulo

Abstract. When do presidential candidates use populist communication, and does its prevalence vary across policy domains? We address these questions using an original dataset of 11,885 tweets from nine Brazilian presidential candidates during the 2022 elections. Drawing on the ideational approach, we operationalize populist discourse as the co-occurrence of people-centrism and anti-elitism, measured with fine-tuned BERT-based classifiers, and classify policy domains with the Comparative Agendas Project framework. Our findings reveal substantial heterogeneity across candidates, challenging expectations that populist communication uniformly intensifies during campaigns or systematically varies across policy domains according to ideology. Rather than increasing uniformly during the campaign, populist appeals escalate strategically for some candidates as elections approach, while remaining stable for others throughout the electoral year. We propose a typology distinguishing opportunistic from consistent populists. Across policy domains, government operations serve as a baseline facilitating populist framing. Left-wing candidates increase populist rhetoric in labor/employment, consistent with issue ownership expectations, but right-wing candidates reduce populist appeals in their traditionally owned domains of law and crime and civil rights, contrary to expectations. Overall, we show that populism is neither a universal campaign imperative nor a content-neutral communication style, but a flexible discursive frame shaped by candidate strategy, electoral context, and policy content.

Read article →

Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

Defensive networks provide basis for late pre-Hispanic Andean polities

2026-10-01 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2617622123

Lauren E. Kohut; Elizabeth Arkush; Ryan D. Smith; Romuald Housse; Nicholas Suarez; Steven A. Wernke

Archaios; Department of Anthropology, University of Pittsburgh; Department of Anthropology, Vanderbilt University; Department of Chemistry, Physics, Geology and the Environment, Winthrop University; Instituto Frances de Estudios Andinos

Abstract. Regional polities may emerge from the development of a centralized hierarchy of a specific political regime, or from bottom-up patterns of interaction and collective action, especially mutual defense. In this study, we assess the proposition that the development of late pre-Hispanic polities of the south-central Andes was significantly shaped by defensive networks of pukaras (hillforts), which were in turn shaped by variable affordances for fortification in the mountainous Andean landscape. Pukaras are very common in the Andean highlands and date overwhelmingly to 1250 to 1500 CE, reflecting a period of widespread concern with violent conflict. We apply a combination of formal spatial and network analyses to a dataset of 1,287 hillforts identified in a satellite imagery survey of over 150,000 km 2 in the south-central Andean highlands. Starting from the premise that interaction and mutual aid were key to defensive cooperation, we define and weight network edges between hillfort nodes based on intervisibility and walking cost. Groupings of pukaras are identified using formal network analysis and community detection. Analysis reveals substantial regional diversity in the structure of these defensive networks. Larger but less cohesive networks developed in open terrain that facilitated movement, interaction, and visual connection, while smaller, more cohesive networks emerged in more rugged terrain. These patterns correspond broadly to the size and characteristics of sociopolitical units evidenced in independent archaeological and ethnohistorical sources. This study highlights how interactions between local landscapes, levels of conflict, and social patterns of defensive cooperation participated in the formation of late pre-Hispanic polities.

Read article →

Classifying strategy use in multiattribute subjective choice: Application to conjoint experiments in political science

2026-09-28 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2613113123

Nidhi V. Banavar; Kirk Bansak

Department of Political Science, University of California Berkeley

Abstract. Conjoint experiments are extensively used across multiple disciplines to make inferences about preferences over multiattribute alternatives. Much previous research has analyzed the importance of attributes at the aggregate level. Here, we focus on understanding individual-level behavior and, specifically, on strategy use. We present a Bayesian cognitive model of strategy use that performs attribute weight inference (how important an attribute is), attribute level inference (which value of the attribute is favored), and latent-mixture inference to classify strategy use among well-established strategies in cognitive science. We then validate and apply our model to two conjoint experiments (N = 3,762) focusing on three political domains (attitudes toward immigrants, political candidates, and climate policy). We find that the simplest heuristic strategy is the highest probability in all conditions and that approximately 67-76% of subjects are classified as using different strategies depending on the political domain. Our model additionally highlights how aggregate-level inference on the weight of an attribute can be meaningfully decomposed by individual differences in strategy use and preferences over attributes. In addition, our experiments include a set of experimental design manipulations that increase different dimensions of complexity and show their impact on strategy classification.

Read article →

The economic returns to citizenship: Evidence from a meta-analysis

2026-09-28 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2617804123

Jens Hainmueller; David D. Laitin

Department of Political Science, Stanford University; Immigration Policy Lab, Stanford University

Abstract. Citizenship is widely summarized as producing a "naturalization premium" for immigrants, but naturalization is selected: immigrants who naturalize differ in language, residence, employment, and motivation. We provide a quantitative meta-analysis of citizenship effects on immigrant earnings, synthesizing 60 preferred estimates from 31 studies. How a study separates the effect of citizenship from selection into citizenship-its identification strategy-explains more variation in estimates than destination country, citizenship regime, or any other study feature we code. Averaging published estimates with a multilevel random-effects model yields a pooled premium of 9.9% (95% CI 5.1 to 14.9), and 11.0% (95% CI 5.7 to 16.6) when pooling within study-country cells. But this average conceals sharp differences across research designs. The randomized encouragement study relying on a lottery to overcome selection implies a near-zero effect of 1.9% (95% CI 1.3 to 5.3); the regression-discontinuity study yields 11.3% (95% CI 5.2 to 17.8); estimates from policy reforms and within-unit panels are positive on average but too imprecise to distinguish from either zero or the pooled average; and observational instrumental-variable estimates average 53.0% (95% CI 27.6 to 83.5). Excluding observational instrumental-variable estimates reduces the pooled premium to 6.0% (95% CI 3.8 to 8.2). Reanalyzing the randomized trial data shows the same pattern: Experimental estimates are near zero, while an observational difference-in-differences comparison based on self-selected citizenship uptake implies a 9.6% gain (95% CI 4.0 to 15.5) four years post lottery, a bias standard pretrend tests do not detect. The published citizenship premium is positive, but its size and causal interpretation depend on research design.

Read article →

Uneven attention to climate tipping points

2026-09-28 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2618666123

Heming Wang; Bingyu Chen; Fengmei Ma; Nico Wunderling; Timothy M. Lenton; Asaf Tzachor

Center for Collective Learning, Corvinus Institute for Advanced Studies, Corvinus University of Budapest; Center for Critical Computational Studies, Goethe University Frankfurt; Commonwealth Scientific and Industrial Research Organisation; Global Systems Institute, University of Exeter; Institute for Technology and Humanity, Centre for the Study of Existential Risk, University of Cambridge; Key Laboratory of Eco-Industry (Ministry of Ecology and Environment), School of Metallurgy, Northeastern University; Potsdam Institute for Climate Impact Research, Member of the Leibniz Association; School of Sustainability, Aviram Sustainability and Climate Program, Reichman University; Senckenberg Research Institute and Natural History Museum, Member of the Leibniz Association; State Key Laboratory of Regional and Urban Ecology, Institute of Urban Environment, Chinese Academy of Sciences

Abstract. Climate tipping points have moved from theoretical concern to a practical challenge for climate-risk assessment and governance. Yet whether scientific attention is aligned with risk-relevant characteristics of climate tipping elements (CTEs) has not been systematically assessed. Across 20,736 CTE-specific records spanning 2000-2025 and addressing 14 tipping elements, attention was concentrated on the Greenland Ice Sheet and Atlantic Meridional Overturning Circulation, while Boreal Permafrost (abrupt thaw) and the North Atlantic Subpolar Gyre received comparatively limited attention despite their relatively low estimated warming thresholds. Explicit engagement with risk-relevant tipping dynamics, including abrupt transitions, hysteresis, or irreversibility, was also limited. These patterns may influence which tipping risks can be most readily assessed, prioritized, and governed.

Read article →

Science Advances

Correcting for spatial and temporal dependence in estimating the economic effect of extreme heat

2026-10-02 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEG1967

Abraham J. Wyner; Ryan S. Brill

University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA, USA.

Abstract. Callahan and Mankin argue that extreme heat, measured by maximum 5-day average temperature, has a precise and economically meaningful effect on subnational gross domestic product per-capita growth. We reexamine this claim and find that the reported precision does not survive methods that respect the data's spatial and temporal dependence. Country-preserving permutations and postselection correction substantially widen marginal-effect intervals. The estimates are also highly sensitive to influential countries and years, with exclusions sometimes collapsing the effect or reversing its sign. A hierarchical Bayesian model with region-within-country structure and AR(1) year effects yields much larger uncertainty, shrinks the estimated effect by 67 to 90%, and produces credible intervals spanning zero. Last, rolling out-of-sample tests show that adding extreme-climate variables does not improve prediction over models without them. We conclude that the claimed precision is not sustained once dependence, model selection, and influential observations are handled appropriately.

Read article →

Psychological and computational evidence that merit is a constructed evaluative process

2026-10-02 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEH5472

Sarah Vahed; Alan G. Sanfey

Behavioural Science Institute, Radboud University, Netherlands.; Donders Institute for Brain, Cognition and Behaviour, Radboud University, Netherlands.

Abstract. Merit is a foundational moral principle invoked to justify inequality between people, yet an individual's productivity is shaped not only by their efforts but also their opportunities. How, then, do people construct merit judgements? Across four preregistered, incentivized studies with US-based samples (total N = 759), we provide psychological and computational evidence that merit is not the product of a fixed rule, but rather the outcome of a subjective valuation. In a two-stage paradigm, participants first completed a real-effort tournament that dissociated performance (effort) from structural productivity (output dependent on opportunity). Thereafter, groups of observers and stakeholders allocated resources to tournament players. Across studies, a player's performance and structural productivity influenced how people judged deservingness. Computational modeling revealed that decision-makers integrated these dimensions of merit into a value computation that shaped allocations. Crucially, individuals differed in their latent weighting patterns, yielding subgroups with directly opposing conceptions of deservingness. By revealing merit as a nonuniform ideal, these findings provide a mechanistic account of how deservingness is determined, helping explain the compelling yet contested nature of meritocracy.

Read article →

Previous Week Catch-Up

Communication Research

Predicting Irritation Disclosures in Romantic Relationships: Testing and Extending the Revelation Risk Model

2026-09-25 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261490466

Rudy C. Pett; Anita L. Vangelisti

Saint Louis University, MO, USA; University of Texas at Austin, USA

Abstract. Feelings of irritation often emerge in romantic relationships. However, the theoretical mechanisms predicting whether individuals disclose these feelings to their romantic partner remain limited and largely reliant on examining indicators of future behavior rather than actual future behavior. Using a two-month, longitudinal survey design involving 448 participants, the current study tested the Revelation Risk Model (RRM) as a mechanism for predicting whether individuals would disclose or conceal feelings of irritation about their romantic partner. Relationship power was also incorporated as an additional predictor. The original RRM components (i.e., closeness, risk, communication efficacy, willingness to disclose) collectively predicted whether individuals disclosed or concealed feelings of irritation about their romantic partner. Relationship power predicted individuals' communication efficacy, as well as perceived risk associated with disclosing their feelings of irritation. The findings are discussed in terms of their contributions to existing research on disclosure, irritations, and power in romantic relationships.

Read article →

Nature Communications

Revisiting evidence for an attentional tunneling effect caused by scarcity

2026-09-26 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-78074-Y

Fiona tho Pesch; Antonia F. Langenhoff; Mahesh Srinivasan

Abstract. Abstract People in poverty sometimes behave in ways that perpetuate their socioeconomic condition. By one influential account, these behaviors arise from psychological effects of scarcity on attention that create greater focus toward managing scarce resources, at the cost of attention to potentially-beneficial information outside of this 'tunnel'. Although the tunneling hypothesis has been widely discussed in academia and beyond, its direct empirical support derives primarily from a landmark study by Shah et al. (2012) in which participants played games while their access to resources was experimentally manipulated, rendering participants either 'rich' or 'poor'. Here, we present new analyses that contest the original interpretation of the data, showing that the behavioral differences between 'rich' and 'poor' participants are more parsimoniously explained by the game's structure than by an attentional shift caused by the scarcity manipulation-a conclusion we substantiate through an additional experiment. We contextualize our findings within the literature on scarcity and attention, and highlight the need for greater clarity regarding the tunneling hypothesis itself.

Read article →

Nature Human Behaviour

Meritocracy and inequality acceptance

2026-09-21 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02567-5

Alexander W. Cappelen; Bertil Tungodden

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

The case for gender quotas

2026-09-21 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02521-5

Jennifer M. Piscopo

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

Understanding the structural and psychological bases of inequality

2026-09-21 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02600-7

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

Messaging strategies and the emergence of echo chambers in collective decision-making

2026-09-22 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2613908123

Ling-Wei Kong; Naomi Ehrich Leonard; Andrew M. Hein

Center for Applied Mathematics, Cornell University; Department of Computational Biology, Cornell University; Department of Mechanical and Aerospace Engineering, Princeton University

Abstract. Collective decision-making arises from individual agents integrating their own personal observations with information obtained from social partners. In many biological systems that exhibit collective decision-making, the process by which social information is produced, transmitted, and used is subject to two key constraints. First, individuals often do not observe the internal states or personal observations of their neighbors; instead, they observe neighbors' discrete actions. Second, agents often have limited attention and preferentially attend to a subset of the social signals that are most salient. Using methods from nonlinear dynamics, we show that either of these constraints can cause collective accuracy to become extremely sensitive to the weight individuals place on the information they receive from others. This sensitivity arises from the spontaneous formation of echo chamber-like states in which individuals receive and transmit homogeneous social messages. Under such conditions, collectives become locked in self-reinforcing states that prevent them from tracking changes in the environment. We reveal the mathematical basis of this phenomenon, and show that it emerges not only in generic models of collective decision-making but also in models developed to describe specific biological systems, including neural circuits, eusocial insect colonies, and mobile animal groups. Finally, we identify biologically plausible mechanisms through which individuals may reduce the risk of echo chamber formation and achieve robust yet sensitive collective decisions without requiring fine-tuning parameters. Our results reveal how fundamental constraints on communication shape the dynamics and reliability of collective decisions across diverse biological systems.

Read article →

Science

What should governance reconsider as digital technologies change?

2026-09-24 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEL4485

Urs Gasser

Urs Gasser is professor of Public Policy, Governance and Innovative Technology, rector of the Hochschule fur Politik Munchen, and dean of the School of Social Sciences and Technology, Technical University of Munich, Munich, Germany.

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

White House efforts to control NIH grants lead to new court challenge and Oval Office tussle

2026-09-24 · DOI 10.1126/SCIENCE.AEM6547

Jocelyn Kaiser

Abstract. Lawsuit argues political screening of grants violates researchers' freedom of speech

Read article →

Science Advances

Measuring the effects of alternatives to policing in an American city

2026-09-25 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEM0857

C. Brandon Ogbunugafor; Michael Ralph

Center for an Equitable Economy and Sustainable Society, Howard University, Washington, DC 20059, USA.; Department of Afro-American Studies, Howard University, Washington, DC 20059, USA.; Department of Anthropology, Yale University, New Haven, CT 06511, USA.; Department of Ecology and Evolutionary Biology, Yale University, New Haven, CT 06520, USA.; Public Health Modeling Unit, Yale School of Public Health, New Haven, CT 06510, USA.; Santa Fe Institute, Santa Fe, NM 87501, USA.

Abstract. CAHOOTS data provide an opportunity to examine how three new diversion metrics clarify the measurable benefits, limits, and policy significance of an alternative-to-policing program.

Read article →

Social Physiology: Human homeostasis is more efficient in social proximity

2026-09-25 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEG4937

Monia Masalha; Matan Cohen; Maayan Aloni; Einav Toledo; Ella Stahl; Diane Shachar; Or Eliav; Shai Fuchs; Shir Atzil

Department of Psychology, The Hebrew University of Jerusalem, Jerusalem, Israel.; Paediatric Endocrine and Diabetes Unit, Edmond and Lily Safra Children's Hospital, Sheba Medical Center, Ramat Gan, Israel.

Abstract. Physiological homeostasis is traditionally viewed as an individual process optimized through evolution to minimize the energetic costs of regulation. However, it remains unknown whether social proximity enhances the efficiency of homeostatic regulation, including in systems not traditionally viewed as socially sensitive. Glucose metabolism is one such system. In a set of preregistered experiments, we found that glucose homeostasis following a carbohydrate challenge is more efficient in a Social condition than an Alone condition, exhibiting lower perturbation amplitude and faster recovery (n = 108). The social benefit in homeostasis replicated in thermoregulation during a cold challenge (n = 116) and in sympathetic regulation during stress in adults (n = 115) and infants (n = 56). These findings demonstrate Social Physiology, a cross-domain principle whereby physiological homeostasis is more efficient in social proximity. Evolutionarily, Social Physiology reveals a psychobiological benefit of sociality, beyond its behavioral and ecological advantages, that may contribute to the emergence and maintenance of social bonds.

Read article →